The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called Conformity with the World

Āryalokānuvartananāmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 200 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་འཇིག་རྟེན་གྱི་རྗེས་སུ་འཇུག་པར་འཇུག་པ་ཞེས་བྱ་བ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མདོ་

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called Conformity with the World, known in Sanskrit as the Lokānuvartana Sūtra and in Tibetan as 'Phags pa 'jig rten gyi rjes su 'thun par 'jug pa zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, is a short Mahāyāna discourse composed entirely in verse. Requested by Mañjughoṣa for the sake of beings in times to come, the Buddha explains that the buddhas are wholly beyond the world, free of elaboration, and inconceivable even to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, yet out of compassion they outwardly conform to worldly ways in order to guide beings. In a long series of verses, each ending with the refrain "This is conformity with the world," it shows how a buddha who is never born, never ill, and never hungry nonetheless displays a birth from parents, childhood, austerities, eating, bathing, illness, and old age, and how the ultimate truth of emptiness is taught through the conventions of words. It is Toh 200 in the Kangyur, in the General Sūtra section, and was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla together with the Tibetan editor-translator Yeshé Dé.

In the language of India: āryalokānubrtannāmamahāyānasūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called Conformity with the World.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time.

The King of Sages was dwelling on the mountain,
Gazed upon from before him
By bodhisattvas, great beings,
And by the śrāvakas.

Then the wise Mañjughoṣa
Bowed and said this to the Victor:
"For the sake of beings in times to come,
Great Hero, please explain

The sublime sūtra from which arise
The qualities of all the buddhas,

Profound, vast, and perfect.
You of supreme intelligence, best of speakers, please explain it."

The Protector of the World
Said to his heart-born son, his dear and supreme one:
"Turn your mind to one-pointed attention.
Listen, and now I shall explain."

The intelligent one asked about the qualities,
And the Tathāgata declared:
"You supreme beings who speak the Dharma,
Listen to this nature of reality.

The Tathāgatas are beyond measure.
Though all the pratyekabuddhas
And the śrāvakas, in every way,
Reckon up the perfect buddhas,

The Tathāgata is free of elaboration,
So what need is there to say
That all childish beings who engage in elaboration
Cannot know the victors?

Buddhas alone fully know the Buddha,
What the nature of a buddha is,
What the body and mind of the self-arisen one are like,
And what his wisdom is like.

Though the lamps of the world, the guides,
Appear within the world,
They are not mingled with the world,
Yet they show an appearance in the world.

Body and the activity of body,
Whatever is expressed in speech,
Mind and the thoughts of mind,
All these of the Victor are beyond the world.

Out of loving care for the world,
The Protectors of the World, the Makers of Light,
Teach the Dharma to beings
In keeping with how the world understands.

Through conduct that is beyond the world
All the buddhas are truly exalted.
Their activity is beyond the world,
And its ripening is unsurpassed.

If the guides of the world
Did not conform to the world,
No one would know the nature of a buddha,
Nor would anyone know the Buddha.

The protectors who wish to benefit the whole world,
Possessed of miraculous powers,
Self-arisen and free from all evil:
Their movements are beyond conception.

The bodies of the sugatas
Are not born of sexual union,
Yet they show a father and a mother:
This is conformity with the world.

They arise from the perfection of wisdom
Practiced for countless koṭis of eons,
Yet they show childhood:
This is conformity with the world.

The Buddha's light is beyond measure,
Illuminating the ten directions,
Yet he shows a light extending one fathom:
This is conformity with the world.

The best of humans never
Touches the ground with his two feet,
Yet he shows himself on roads and streets:
This is conformity with the world.

He has condemned those sense pleasures
And is truly exalted above the mire of desire,
Yet he shows a son and the like:
This is conformity with the world.

Ever since the time of Dīpaṃkara
The Tathāgata has been free of attachment,
Yet he called Rāhula his son:

This is conformity with the world.

He declared, "I am supreme
In the world together with its gods,"
Yet he went forth and sought the Dharma:
This is conformity with the world.

The Great Sage sat in the shade
Of the rose-apple tree and showed himself meditating,
And he practiced austerities for six years:
This is conformity with the world.

Nondual, in this very field,
Seated at the seat of awakening,
He shows the taming of Māra:
This is conformity with the world.

He is a buddha of unequaled awakening,
The teacher of the world with its gods,
Yet he shows a hesitant mind:
This is conformity with the world.

The Hero, possessed of great compassion,
Came here in order to teach,
Yet he waited to be entreated:
This is conformity with the world.

The knowing of the self-arisen ones
Never lapses and returns,
Yet they show recollection:
This is conformity with the world.

For the perfect buddhas
There is no coming and no going,
Yet they appear to depart:
This is conformity with the world.

The victors are like space;
They abide in no phenomenon whatsoever,
Yet they appear as if rising up:
This is conformity with the world.

Their feet are like lotus petals,
Never soiled by dust,
Yet they wash their feet:
This is conformity with the world.

They have no stain at all;
Their bodies are like the color of gold,
Yet the perfect buddhas bathe:
This is conformity with the world.

Their mouths have the fragrance of the lotus;
Their teeth are like stainless pearls,
Yet they chew tooth-sticks:
This is conformity with the world.

Though they have no hunger,
They partake of food,
And it bears great fruit for the giver:
This is conformity with the world.

Since their bodies are hard like vajra,
They have no discharges,
Yet they go to the privy:
This is conformity with the world.

Though they have no illness,
In order to gather the Saṅgha
They take medicine:
This is conformity with the world.

The Buddha is endowed with all qualities,
And his body knows no change,
Yet he shows old age:
This is conformity with the world.

Countless world systems
He shakes with his big toe,
Yet he shows weakness:
This is conformity with the world.

Though the Tathāgata, the dharmakāya,
Is fully endowed with a mind-made body,
He shows a body that festers:

This is conformity with the world.

Though buddhas have no conceptual thought,
In keeping with the spheres of beings
They conceive their actions:
This is conformity with the world.

They are always in meditative equipoise,
Yet they appear standing, sitting, and walking,
And likewise sleeping:
This is conformity with the world.

The perfect buddhas, who cannot be overcome,
Seek out shade against heat
And sun against cold:
This is conformity with the world.

Like Brahmā in the abode of Brahmā,
The Victor is ever clothed,
Yet he accepts robes:

This is conformity with the world.

The crown of his head cannot be seen,
And no razor could ever cut it,
Yet he shows the shaving of his head:
This is conformity with the world.

Having fully cultivated the bases of miraculous power,
They display miracles,
Yet they also appear to engage in meditative concentration:
This is conformity with the world.

All the guides of the world,
Though they have attained the finest of flavors,
Partake of poor food:
This is conformity with the world.

Through all their inexhaustible merit
All the buddhas are truly exalted,
Yet they show themselves receiving nothing:
This is conformity with the world.

Having attained the food of joy,
They could remain for koṭis of eons,
Yet they always partake of food:
This is conformity with the world.

Exalted by the perfection of merit,
Though they have obtained divine garments,
They wear robes of rags from the rubbish heap:
This is conformity with the world.

The guides have wholly given up
The celestial palaces of Akaniṣṭha,
And they resort to huts of grass:
This is conformity with the world.

Though the guides with the breath of their mouths
Could dry up the great ocean,
They hold up a shelter against the rain:
This is conformity with the world.

Though by merely forming the intention
They tame countless koṭis of māras,
They show the obstructions of Māra:
This is conformity with the world.

The view of "I" and "mine"
Does not exist in the self-arisen ones,
Yet they speak of "I" and "mine":
This is conformity with the world.

Though for the protector, the Buddha,
There is no phenomenon that he does not know,
He questions others:
This is conformity with the world.

Though the guides appear
For the sake of all beings,
They are seen in deep solitude:
This is conformity with the world.

Though they have no variety of bodies,
In keeping with the inclinations of beings
They emanate physical bodies:

This is conformity with the world.

The Tathāgata is not stirred
By the sounds and voices of the whole world,
Yet he resorts to quiet places:
This is conformity with the world.

The perfect buddhas have no elaboration,
And all phenomena are clear to them,
Yet they speak in an elaborate way:
This is conformity with the world.

Phenomena that are without names
They express to beings
Through names beyond conception:
This is conformity with the world.

They know that phenomena are without beings
And utterly without entities,
Yet they tame many beings:
This is conformity with the world.

Though it is not that the very one who did a deed
Is the one who experiences it,
They show who it was that did it:
This is conformity with the world.

Though the supreme beings directly perceive
All phenomena to be empty,
They show death, transmigration, and birth:
This is conformity with the world.

No one ever passes on
From this world to another existence,
Yet they show saṃsāra:
This is conformity with the world.

They hold the aggregates, the elements,
And the sense sources to be of one nature,
Yet they show the three realms:
This is conformity with the world.

In the three times
No nature of beings is found,
Yet they show the realm of beings:
This is conformity with the world.

Free of any not knowing,
They know all and see all,
Yet they do not speak of the beginning:
This is conformity with the world.

They have realized phenomena
Correctly, just as they are and not otherwise,
Yet they show the setting aside of questions:
This is conformity with the world.

They fully know all phenomena
To be profound in the ultimate sense,
Yet they show them as manifold:
This is conformity with the world.

In keeping with the dispositions of beings
They teach the truths of the noble ones,
And they also show them to be false:
This is conformity with the world.

Though a hundred koṭis of māras
Could not divide the Saṅgha,
He shows a schism in the Saṅgha:
This is conformity with the world.

Not a single phenomenon has been trained in,
Nor is there anything untrained,
Yet they show trainees and those beyond training:
This is conformity with the world.

As for the essential nature of conditioned things,
By that essential nature there is neither liberation nor bondage,
Yet they show liberation:
This is conformity with the world.

Though there is no going to nirvāṇa,
They teach beings
That the arhat goes there:

This is conformity with the world.

He sees neither benefit nor its absence,
Yet the best of speakers
Speaks of cessation and the ultimate:
This is conformity with the world.

Though he fully shows the absence of entities,
The entity of clarity, free of turbidity,
He says that phenomena are never wasted:
This is conformity with the world.

Though the Tathāgata fully knows
That all phenomena are inexpressible,
He shows expressions:
This is conformity with the world.

The Buddha's knowing is free of attachment,
And he is always in meditative equipoise,
Yet he guards his senses:
This is conformity with the world.

The Tathāgata has a vajra body,
And the Buddha is not ill in the least,
Yet he told a monk, "Recite the factors of awakening":
This is conformity with the world.

All his wrongdoing is wholly exhausted,
And he is exalted by all merit,
Yet he shows the continuity of karma:
This is conformity with the world.

Though for the protector, the Buddha,
There is no final change in the three times,
He shows the setting of boundaries:
This is conformity with the world.

The Tathāgata is the dharmakāya;
As one is, so are all,
Yet he shows distinctions:
This is conformity with the world.

Buddhas, pratyekabuddhas,
Śrāvakas, and ordinary beings,
Saṃsāra and nirvāṇa,
Are distinguished by way of words.

The wisdom of the Buddha is infinite,
Arisen from the dharmadhātu,
Yet he shows buddha fields:
This is conformity with the world.

The perfect buddhas are inconceivable;
The Tathāgata is inconceivable.
It is for the sake of taming beings:
This is conformity with the world.

Though nothing undefiled exists,
The Tathāgata, to the śrāvakas,

Speaks of what is undefiled:
This is conformity with the world.

To his knowing, these are not two,
Yet seeing the three times,
He shows the perception of duality:
This is conformity with the world.

Whoever wishes to know
What the nature of a buddha is, and the Buddha,
Should ask the dharmadhātu:
This is conformity with the world.

Abiding in the acceptance of nonarising,
He always knows perfectly,
And having known, he teaches:
This is conformity with the world.

Always equal to the dharmadhātu,
Without entering and without emerging,
Yet he shows going and staying:
This is conformity with the world.

Though in the unborn
There is neither one nor many,
He shows a variety of stages:

This is conformity with the world.

Though they have no separate bodies,
In countless buddha fields
They emanate physical bodies:
This is conformity with the world.

A hundred koṭis of trichiliocosms counted together
Is what is called a buddha field,
And there they show birth:
This is conformity with the world.

Though the Tathāgata fully knows
That the Dharma abides at all times,
He turns the wheel of Dharma:
This is conformity with the world.

The Buddha's light is beyond measure,
And his body too is beyond measure,
Yet he shows it as having measure:
This is conformity with the world.

In the dharmadhātu there is nothing supreme,
And it is empty in the three times,
Yet the Supreme One teaches the Dharma:
This is conformity with the world.

Without destruction and without birth,
Though he has become equal to the dharmadhātu,
He shows the eon of burning:
This is conformity with the world.

The dharmadhātu is not established;
It has no essential nature,
Yet he shows renunciation:
This is conformity with the world.

Though he has no seeing whatsoever,
He sees by means of insight,
And he shows all views:
This is conformity with the world.

Though in all phenomena
There is no agent at all,
He shows what is done and not done:
This is conformity with the world.

Though in nirvāṇa and in space
The victors are not counted,
They show the enumerations of the elements:
This is conformity with the world.

Having attained countless powers,
And never falling short in might,
Yet he seeks attendants:
This is conformity with the world.

Though the buddhas, the guides,
Never have a childish mind,
They tame those childish beings:
This is conformity with the world.

Though the Tathāgata has gone beyond
All who possess good qualities,
He says to them, "I am other":
This is conformity with the world.

The unborn is always born;
Though they do not arise from causes,
It is said they arise through the condition of ignorance:
This is conformity with the world.

The Victor has attained freedom
From the obscuration of gain and honor,
Yet he shows contentment:
This is conformity with the world.

Wherever there appear
Beings to be tamed,
There the guides show their conduct:
This is conformity with the world.

Having gathered the accumulation of the three knowledges,
He clearly shows the producing of knowledge,
Though in this nothing whatsoever is seen:

This is conformity with the world.

As lamps of the world in every place
They tame beings beyond measure,
And they also show the four continents:
This is conformity with the world.

In none of the three worlds
Does any phenomenon or aggregate abide,
Yet he declared that phenomena are established:
This is conformity with the world.

Born at the limit of the three limits,
The Tathāgatas teach
And fully instruct beings:
This is conformity with the world.

Knowing the continuum of all phenomena,
They have abandoned death, transmigration, and birth,
Yet they show all of these:
This is conformity with the world.

For one who sees the unborn,
Ignorance is the obstructor of wisdom,
And he shows the producing of knowledge:
This is conformity with the world.

Though the perfect Buddha is one,
In order to bring beings to maturity
His appearances are beyond conception:
This is conformity with the world.

Those who in later times
Hear such a sūtra as this
And understand it without doubt
Have seen the victors of the past.

When the Protector of the World had spoken thus,
His son Mañjughoṣa and the others
Were overjoyed and rejoiced,
And they praised the words of the Teacher.

This concludes the noble Mahāyāna sūtra called Conformity with the World.

This was translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the chief editor-translator Bandé Yeshé Dé, and was also revised in accordance with the new language standard and finalized.

Herein is contained the Sūtra of Heat.

Translator's Notes

• In the verse on the pratyekabuddhas and śrāvakas, "reckon up" renders bsags pa, whose sense here is unclear; the point is that even they cannot fathom the buddhas, still less ordinary beings. The verse on the Buddha's hesitancy refers to his reluctance to teach after awakening, and "waited to be entreated" renders gsol ba 'debs la gzhes mdzad pa, referring to Brahmā's request that he teach. In the verse on the privy, the text's bshad pa'i sa ("place of teaching") is read as bshang ba'i sa ("privy"), which the context plainly requires; the verse plays on zag pa, both "discharges" and the defiling outflows. The phrase sgrims pa, rendered "hunger," is read from context. The final verse continues into the next piece.
• "The setting aside of questions" renders gzhag pa, taken as the questions the Buddha set aside unanswered. "The setting of boundaries" renders mtshams gcod pa, taken as the establishment of monastic boundaries (sīmā). The final verse is completed in the next piece.
• In the verse on the Buddha's light, the Tibetan reads "his body is not immeasurable" (dpag tu med min), which contradicts the following line; it has been read as "beyond measure" (dpag tu med cing), as the sense requires. The last line, "Herein is contained the Sūtra of Heat," appears to be the title page of the following text in the collection, not part of this sūtra.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.